

STRIKE At Will

Two separate pilot strikes in a month paralyse civil aviation, affecting thousands of passengers and making a mockery of the open skies policy

PARVEEN NEGI



Rs 800 Cr

IS WHAT AIR INDIA WILL SAVE
BY CUTTING ALLOWANCES WHICH WILL REDUCE THE SALARY OF ITS EXECUTIVE PILOTS BY BETWEEN 20 AND 50 PER CENT.

CAPTAIN V.K. BHALLA ANNOUNCING THE CALL-OFF IN DELHI

|By Sandeep Unnithan|

What's the most powerful fighter in the air these days?' goes the joke in the corridors of Rajiv Gandhi Bhavan. 'Not the MiG, not the Sukhoi, it's the commercial airline pilot.' In two crippling strikes in September, pilots have shown airlines who holds the controls by simply refusing to fly. In unrelated strikes a fortnight apart, commercial pilots caused Jet Airways and the already beleaguered Air India to grind to a near-complete halt leading to

flight cancellations and leaving irate passengers stranded across the country from New Delhi to Port Blair. The strikes have since been called off and the pilots have returned to the cockpits, but after flexing their muscles and proving a point: push us around at your own financial peril.

At Jet Airways, which leads the aviation pack with a 26 per cent market share, 500 of 760 pilots went on mass leave for four days causing losses of Rs 100 crore and forcing the management to reinstate four sacked pilots. Air India, which has just 17 per cent of the market, lost over Rs 110

crore in last week's strike. The rancour at Air India began on September 24 when the management decided to slash the allowances given to nearly 200 senior pilots. Each executive pilot, as they are called, takes home between Rs 6 lakh and 8 lakh per month. The cuts in the productivity-linked incentive (PLI) would reduce the salary by between 20 and 50 per cent and save Rs 800 crore for the airline which is already reeling under accumulated losses of Rs 7,000 crore and an annual deficit of Rs 5,000 crore. The airline is looking for a Rs 5,000-crore bailout package from